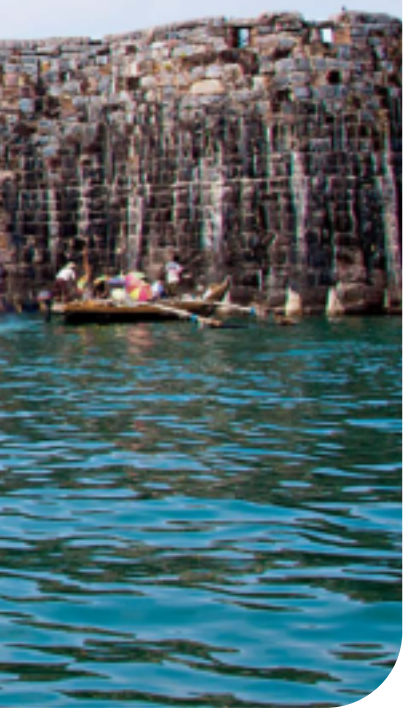


GETTY IMAGES



SHUTTERSTOCK

LAP IT UP Sindhudurg fort is surrounded by water on all sides; (below) the new Shivaji statue at Rajkot fort



at Bhogwe, and each has been a really enriching experience.

Sea Link

Tarkarli, despite being so unspoilt and gorgeous, is perhaps the most developed in terms of catering to tourists. The Indian Institute of Scuba Diving and Aquatic Sports (IISDA) here offers watersports such as snorkelling, scuba diving (excellent training as well), jet skiing and parasailing. On the main road near the beach are a fair number of local eateries and little souvenir shops. Another fascinating spot to visit is Tsunami Island, a sandbar that came up after the 2004 tsunami. Of the other beaches in the neighbourhood, you can enjoy time at Chivla, Devbagh, Bhogwe, Achre, Shiroda, Kunkeshwar, Nivati, Sagareshwar, Talashil Tondavali and Vengurla. The sea is magnificent and, barring a few carts, these beaches are pure paradise. Dolphin safaris are big here, and you are almost assured of getting a glimpse of the lively Indo-Pacific humpback dolphins. After all, it's all part of the magnificent Malvan Marine Sanctuary. Snorkelling, too, is very rewarding, with beautiful schools of fish, and coral.

'Fort'ify Yourself

It's not just sand and surf, the coastal forts here are equally spectacular, the most famous being Sindhudurg Fort, after which the region is named. Built at the behest of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj between 1664 and 1667 AD, it sits in well-fortified splendour on Khurte Island. To get there, I settle into a big boat that takes me across the sea to the slippery stone steps leading up to the fort. The 48-acre expanse encompasses sprawling ramparts, three sweet water wells, a temple dedicated to Shivaji himself, and a museum celebrating the fort and its founder. Folklore has it that the hand and footprints preserved near the top of the ramparts belong to the Maratha king. There's also a 'fake temple', which is supposed to hide an undersea tunnel via which people trapped on the island by the enemy could escape to the mainland! If forts are your thing, you can also explore the older Vijaydurg, Sarjekot and Padmagarh as well as the 17th century fort of Rajkot, where the new 91-foot-tall statue of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj was installed in May.

Culture it Up

A nice change of pace is Sawantwadi, rich with history. Not only can you visit the palace and attached museum that once belonged to the Sawant-Bhonsle rulers, you can even opt to stay in this restored building dating back to 1755 AD (or have a sumptuous meal there!) Of the many shore temples that abound in this area (of note are the Sateri Devi Jal Mandir and Shri Bhadrakali Temple), I was most interested in the Shri Wagheshwar Temple, dedicated to Lord Shiva, which is said to have once had peace-loving tigers visiting it regularly! ■

STAY

Coco Shambhala (2-bedroom villa with private pool starts at Rs 55,000 per night in the low season for a minimum stay of three nights), Sawantwadi Palace Boutique Art Hotel (deluxe suite with private pool starts at Rs 18,880 per night), Parisa Beach Resort (seaview room with a balcony starts at Rs 6,090 per night); MTDC-approved home stays are very affordable